

MARKET NOTE

Arctic Wolf's Incident Response Retainer Plan: Why Didn't Anyone Think of This Before?

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EXECUTIVE SNAPSHOT

FIGURE 1

Executive Snapshot: Arctic Wolf's Incident Response Retainer Plan — Why Didn't Anyone Think of This Before?

Arctic Wolf's Incident360 Retainer shakes up traditional incident response (IR) retainer models by replacing traditional hours-based models. It includes full support for one major incident annually, plus proactive readiness services like tabletop exercises and IR plan reviews. Designed for midmarket organizations and small enterprises, it integrates with Arctic Wolf's MDR platform and aligns with cyberinsurance requirements. Partners can bundle their own services or resell Arctic Wolf's full package. With predictable pricing, rapid SLAs, and built-in planning tools, Incident360 ensures firms are prepared, protected, and positioned to recover quickly from cyberthreats.

Key Takeaways

- Arctic Wolf's Incident360 Retainer offers an outcome-based alternative to traditional incident response retainers by providing predictable coverage and proactive readiness for midmarket and smaller organizations.
- The retainer includes full coverage for one incident per year, with options for additional readiness touch points and a Rapid Response Add-On to accelerate response times.
- Arctic Wolf's IR Dashboard provides tools for incident response planning, cyber-resilience assessment, and insurability evaluation, enhancing preparedness and response efficiency.
- The Incident360 Retainer model shifts risk away from organizations and their cyberinsurance providers to Arctic Wolf, offering a strong ROI and outcome-based approach.
- While beneficial for smaller firms, larger organizations may still prefer traditional hours-based incident response retainer models due to their complex environments and need for more personalized assessments.

Source: IDC, 2025

IN THIS MARKET NOTE

On May 15, 2025, Arctic Wolf announced a new incident response (IR) retainer offering titled Arctic Wolf Incident360 Retainer. Designed as a modernized, assurance-based approach to incident response, this new type of IR retainer addresses the limitations of traditional hours-based retainers. It offers predictable coverage, proactive readiness, and integrated tools to help organizations — especially midmarket and smaller, less security-mature ones — prepare for and respond to cybersecurity incidents effectively.

At the core of the Incident360 Retainer is a coverage model rather than a traditional hours-based one. Each retainer includes full coverage for one incident per year, regardless of type — ransomware, business email compromise (BEC), or other cyberevents.

Arctic Wolf offers three levels of retainers:

- **JumpStart Retainer:** Entry-level plan with a 4-hour SLA, access to IR planning tools, runbooks, and a cyber-resilience assessment (CRA)
- **Incident360 Retainer:** Includes everything in JumpStart, plus a 3-hour SLA, full incident coverage for one incident, and threat intelligence access (Note that restoration services such as reinstalling app and software and patching are capped at 30 hours.)
- **Incident360 Retainer Plus:** Adds three readiness touch points — tabletop exercise, IR plan review, and CRA review — providing a comprehensive readiness and response package

Arctic Wolf also has a Rapid Response Add-On option, which can expedite the response time to one hour and decrease the hourly IR rate.

Customers gain access to Arctic Wolf's unified portal, which includes:

- An IR planner to document response teams, critical systems, and external contacts
- A file repository for storing plans and runbooks, accessible even during network outages
- A cyber-resilience assessment tool aligned with NIST and CIS frameworks
- An insurability report to evaluate alignment with cyberinsurance requirements

Thinking Outside the Box — Opportunities for the Midmarket

Security leaders often end up juggling the need to improve their cybersecurity readiness and maturity levels by utilizing the proactive portions in their IR retainer while gambling that the drawdown on their retainer will not leave them having to go back to the CFO for additional funding should the inevitable cyberattack occur later in the year. The fear of not fully utilizing their IR retainer prior to their expiration at the end of the term is the other side of the seesaw balancing act that is not necessarily healthy.

Many IR providers have terms that indicate that unused retainer funds expire at the end of the term. That's probably why many organizations rush to request a tabletop exercise, CRA review post-Thanksgiving holidays, and try to burn down these retainer hours with readiness activities. The terms provided by IR providers that indicate that retainer funds are a "use-it or lost-it" by the end of the term can leave many security leaders begging for options toward the end of the year. Account managers often bend the rules of the retainer "as a favor" to their customers to allow them to fully utilize their unused retainer funds, but IDC does not see any value in going through these legal gymnastics. Why can't firms find a way to make sure that they are getting full value out of their retainers without risking having the required funding should an incident break out at the end of December?

IDC recognizes that Arctic Wolf's Incident360 Retainer is a completely different and unique way of offering up an IR retainer. For one, it offers a strong outcome-based model and high return on investment (ROI), including a competitive price point, insurability, and fundamentals of incident readiness. Especially in the midmarket and among smaller organizations, the full IR coverage for an incident (with the previously noted recovery hour caps) shifts significant risk away from the firm and its cyberinsurance provider, if they are even fortunate enough to be able to qualify for cyberinsurance. The standard inclusion of select proactive measures (depending on the type of retainer) such as tabletop exercises, incident response planning, and cyber-risk assessments build some cyberincident response muscle memory that should speed up actual incident response should it be needed. Arctic Wolf gains by having a better prepared client base that will require less time and effort to help them respond to any use of the response portion of the IR retainer.

Another noteworthy benefit occurs with the knowledge that too many organizations today go through the effort of building out an incident response plan only to find that their plan is not up to date, or almost as bad, and is inaccessible during a ransomware

event. Arctic Wolf's focus on the midmarket and smaller firms with this offering provides a higher likelihood that not only will the incident response plan be found but also a greater likelihood that it will be applicable to the situation.

Impacts on the Channel

Arctic Wolf is a partner-first organization, and as such, the distinctions between the Incident360 Retainer and the Incident360 Retainer Plus are easily discernable for channel partners. The former allows managed service provider (SP)/MSSP firms to tailor and add their own capabilities (such as red team/purple team and virtual CISO), while the latter one allows an easy pass-through for Arctic Wolf to provide the needed capabilities. This enables channel partners to choose the path that best complements their existing offerings and capabilities, ensuring that Arctic Wolf is supporting its partners and not competing with them.

What Is Missing?

While this is certainly a game changer, this is not Nirvana. Larger organizations are still better suited to utilize the more traditional hours-based engagement model and perhaps more human touch points. In the current Incident360 Retainer packages, the cyber-readiness assessment review is largely taken in a self-driven questionnaire-based approach. For larger organizations that have a more complex environment, this self-driven approach might not be that effective or accurate. Firms that have a lot of IT infrastructure might also require a lot of recovery effort should a full-blown incident occur such as ransomware. They would still benefit by shifting some of their risk to a cyberinsurance provider.

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Related Research

- *RSAC Conference 2025: Agentic AI and a Continued Move Toward Integration Emerge as Key Themes* (IDC #US53463525, May 2025)
- *How Is the Effectiveness of Different Cybersecurity Services Ranked by Different Personas?* (IDC #US53351425, April 2025)
- *Revenue Growth for Managed Security SPs and SIs in the GenAI Era Require Four Es* (IDC #US53257725, March 2025)
- *IDC Market Glance: Cybersecurity Channel, 1Q25* (IDC #US52997225, January 2025)
- *IDC Market Glance: Professional Security Services, 3Q24* (IDC #US47972522, September 2024)

Synopsis

This IDC Market Note documents Arctic Wolf's recently announced Incident360 Retainer. This modern, assurance-based approach to incident response addresses limitations of traditional retainers. It provides predictable coverage, proactive readiness, and integrated tools that are especially suited for midmarket and smaller organizations. The retainer includes full coverage for one incident per year and offers various levels with different features.

"Arctic Wolf's Incident360 Retainer breaks the laws of traditional hours-based incident response retainer models. Cost certainty mixed with an outcome-based model will provide IT, cybersecurity, and C-suite leaders with some reduced anxiety when — not if — their incident response retainer gets utilized in a crisis situation." — Craig Robinson, research vice president, Security Services, IDC

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